Ancient Egypt During the New Kingdom

Approximate period: 1550–1070 BCE
Region: Nile Valley, with changing areas of control in Nubia and the Levant
Dynasties: Eighteenth, Nineteenth, and Twentieth

1. Background and Reunification

The New Kingdom followed the Second Intermediate Period, when regional dynasties and rulers known as the Hyksos controlled parts of Egypt. Ahmose I, at the beginning of the Eighteenth Dynasty, consolidated the reunification of Egypt and expelled Hyksos authority from the Nile Delta. The New Kingdom is associated with military campaigns beyond Egypt's borders, territorial expansion, monumental building projects, and a growing influence of the cult of Amun.

The phrase *Egyptian Empire* describes outward expansion rather than an administrative structure identical to a modern state. Control over Nubia and the cities of the Levant fluctuated and relied on garrisons, governors, diplomacy, and local rulers.

2. Hatshepsut: Power and Legitimacy

Hatshepsut ruled during the fifteenth century BCE and adopted royal titles and imagery in a political system usually governed by male pharaohs. Her reign is known for her mortuary temple at Deir el-Bahari and for images of a trading expedition to the land of Punt. Punt's exact location remains disputed, although it is generally associated with the Red Sea region and the Horn of Africa.

Royal monuments present official accounts of political and religious achievement; they should not be treated as neutral reports of events.

3. Thutmose III and Military Expansion

Thutmose III led campaigns in the Levant, including the campaign associated with Megiddo in the fifteenth century BCE. Inscriptions at Karnak describe campaigns and war booty. These are valuable historical sources but also forms of royal propaganda. Egyptian influence in the Near East operated through tribute, diplomatic gifts, alliances, and military intervention.

4. Amenhotep III and International Diplomacy

During the fourteenth century BCE, the Egyptian court maintained relations with Babylon, Mitanni, Hatti, and other powers. The Amarna Letters, mostly written in Akkadian cuneiform, document correspondence among major kings and requests from client rulers in the Levant. These texts reveal the importance of gold, dynastic marriages, diplomatic gifts, and international prestige.

5. Akhenaten and Religious Change

Akhenaten, a ruler of the Eighteenth Dynasty, promoted the worship of the solar disk Aten and established a new royal center at Akhetaten, identified with Amarna. Scholars debate whether his religious program should be described as strict monotheism or a form of exclusive worship. After his death, court religion changed direction and many traditional institutions returned to prominence.

Tutankhamun, a successor from the same period, is particularly famous for his nearly intact tomb, discovered in 1922 by a team led by Howard Carter. The archaeological significance of the burial should not be confused with a very long reign or major territorial conquests.

6. Ramesses II and the Hittites

Ramesses II, a Nineteenth Dynasty pharaoh, ruled in the thirteenth century BCE and commissioned monumental construction, including the temples at Abu Simbel. The rivalry with the Hittite Empire focused especially on control of territories in Syria. At **Kadesh**, around **1274 BCE**, an Egyptian army confronted the forces of Hittite king Muwatalli II. Egyptian inscriptions describe the pharaoh's victory in heroic terms, but modern historians interpret the military outcome more cautiously.

Later Egypt and Hatti concluded a **peace treaty**, generally dated to about **1259 BCE**, under Ramesses II and Hattusili III. The treaty illustrates international diplomacy and mutual interest in maintaining stable borders.

7. The Nile Economy and Society

Agriculture depended on the Nile's flood cycle, irrigation, and the organization of labor. Wheat, barley, and flax were important crops. Temples and royal institutions held land, collected produce, and organized workshops. Craftspeople at Deir el-Medina, who worked on royal tombs, left records of labor, rations, disputes, and family life.

Egyptian society was hierarchical: the pharaoh, administrators, priests, soldiers, artisans, and farmers had different roles. Legal and economic status varied. Modern concepts of citizenship or slavery do not map perfectly onto ancient Egyptian institutions.

8. Writing, Religion, and the Afterlife

Egyptians used hieroglyphs in monumental settings and cursive writing, particularly hieratic, in administrative texts. Scribes were essential for accounts, taxes, storage, and correspondence. Egyptian religion included deities such as Amun-Ra, Osiris, Isis, and Hathor, together with rituals associated with maintaining the cosmic order known as *maat*.

The tombs of the Valley of the Kings and funerary texts reveal beliefs about the journey into the afterlife. Practices and beliefs were not completely uniform across time or region.

9. Crises of the Twelfth and Eleventh Centuries BCE

During the Twentieth Dynasty, Egypt experienced economic and political difficulties. Ramesses III is known for inscriptions describing battles against groups conventionally known as the **Sea Peoples**. The identities and movements of these groups remain debated. There is no evidence that one single attack explains all the transformations of the eastern Mediterranean.

By about **1070 BCE**, the political unity of the New Kingdom had fragmented and Egypt entered the Third Intermediate Period. Institutions, communities, and cultural traditions continued even as political power was redistributed.

10. Comparison with Other Bronze Age Civilizations

Feature	New Kingdom Egypt	Hittite Empire	Mycenaean World
Main region	Nile Valley	Anatolia	Mainland Greece
Writing	Hieroglyphs and hieratic	Cuneiform	Linear B
Major centers	Thebes, Memphis, Pi-Ramesses	Hattusa	Mycenae, Pylos, Tiryns
External connections	Nubia, Levant, Hatti	Syria, Egypt, Ahhiyawa	Aegean, Anatolia, Levant
Changes around 1200 BCE	Crises but continued state traditions	Dissolution of empire	Collapse of palatial system

11. Short Timeline

- **c. 1550 BCE:** Reunification under Ahmose I and beginning of the New Kingdom.
- **15th century BCE:** Hatshepsut and the campaigns of Thutmose III.
- **14th century BCE:** Amarna diplomacy and Akhenaten's religious program.
- **c. 1274 BCE:** Battle of Kadesh.
- **c. 1259 BCE:** Egyptian-Hittite peace treaty.
- **12th century BCE:** Ramesses III and regional upheaval.
- **c. 1070 BCE:** End of the New Kingdom.

12. Key Terms for RAG Queries

Ahmose I — pharaoh associated with Egypt's reunification.
Hatshepsut — female pharaoh known for monumental projects.
Thutmose III — ruler associated with campaigns in the Levant.
Akhenaten — pharaoh who promoted worship of Aten.
Ramesses II — pharaoh associated with Kadesh and the treaty with the Hittites.
Amarna — royal center and source of diplomatic archives.
Maat — the principle of cosmic and social order.

Methodological note: Dates are approximate when the chronology is disputed. This document distinguishes material and written evidence from modern interpretation where possible. Prepared as educational material for text extraction, chunking, and semantic retrieval (RAG).